



Election program

[Resolutions](#)

Building a citizens' Europe

Manifesto of the ELDR Party for the European Elections in 1994

Approved at Torquay on 10 December 1993

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Introduction

The last five years in the European Parliament have seen several important steps in the development of the European Union.

The achievement of the internal free market at the end of 1992 has led logically to the Maastricht Treaty on European Union. During this period communism has virtually disappeared and the East is now united within the Union. Four other European countries, members of the European Economic Area, are now linked with the European Union (EU) in the European Economic Area membership. Central and East European countries are seeking to join us in the hope of economic and political recovery in the way Marshall Aid did in Western Europe. We support the further enlargement of the European Union.

At the same time, however, Europe has suffered many setbacks which give our citizens cause for concern. We have yet another economic crisis. Unemployment has grown to an unacceptable level and illiberal solutions are supported by too many. In order to foster the economic development of Central and Eastern European countries, the European Union should open its markets to these countries. More effort in terms of political, financial and technical assistance will be required. We must ensure that Eastern Europe reaches a sufficient level to join the European Union. Furthermore, we must prevent the resurgence of political and economic instability, a revival of nationalism, outright discrimination and human rights in a number of countries, as for example in former Yugoslavia, which remains a major concern.

Some people believe that the process of European integration has reached its limits. The alleged interference of the Brussels administration in national affairs must be ended. The principle of subsidiarity is in some cases being abused as a flag behind which some of our Member States seek to preserve the domination of the nation state. We in ELDR regard subsidiarity as a principle of shared responsibilities between all levels of democratic government. According to the principle of subsidiarity, powers should be exercised at the lowest possible level, and at the European level can only be exercised if the problem cannot be dealt with effectively by local, regional or national government. Subsidiarity is a key principle of our campaign for transparency and deregulation.

Citizens feel insecure in the face of economic recession, political instability, and rising unemployment. They have lost confidence in the ability of politicians and governments to address their fears. Since the signing of the process of the Maastricht Treaty, the Community has shown its ability to address the concerns of the population of the Member Countries.

European Liberal Democrats and Reformers believe in a society where individual e flourish under the rule of law. Our political objective is to enhance the well-being environment by building an ecologically sustainable social market economy. Lib Reformers have always been at the forefront of the process for European Union. Th on decentralised federal characteristics. Narrow-minded state nationalism leac isolation. We will combat such adversarial attitudes, and continue to campaign for liberty and opportunity prevail.

Our priority for the next Parliament is to put into effect the Maastricht Treaty, to str democracy in the Community and to introduce open government. We will work Union closer to the citizen, and to encourage our citizens to exercise their rights an government.

On behalf of European citizens ELDR demands:

- * the evolution of the European Parliament to become a full legislative Union;*
- * the strengthening of the market economy and the promotion of socia*
- * structural, regional and social policies to reinforce cohesion and ensui*
- * agriculture, energy, transport, waste and international developmei environmental sustainability;*
- * cooperation in justice and home affairs, including immigration polic principle of subsidiarity and aimed always to deepen individual liberty to ensure security;*
- * common foreign, security and defence policies to ensure freedoi advancement of all peoples, human rights and world-wide security.*
- * high standards in education, culture and scientific research which economic progress and social emancipation.*

We believe that these demands require continued European integration in order to coherence among governments and solidarity among the citizens.

We call upon all those who believe in our values to support our cause.

BEYOND THE SINGLE MARKET

European economic integration cannot be an end in itself but must contribute prosperity and social justice for our citizens. Over the last five years the European significantly more integrated, but unemployment has risen to unacceptable levels. T from low inflation and a stable currency in terms of a sustainable growth, enhanced higher standard of living.

Economic and Monetary Integration

The realisation of Economic and Monetary Union requires enhanced efforts for e given the more difficult economic situation. This demands from all Member State economic stability and a solid budget policy. The virtual, but not yet completed Sing and the commitments in the Maastricht Treaty to Economic and Monetary Union new questions. These focus on how to combine our steadily integrating economies w

system. The deep economic recession, imbalances in fiscal and monetary policy, and the European Monetary System (EMS) by currency speculation requires the Member States to converge on the convergence criteria, the phased timetable foreseen in the Maastricht Treaty and clear political signals of their determination.

Recent monetary crises have seriously hampered government efforts to secure recovery in Western Europe. Competitive devaluations bring only short-term advantage for sustained economic recovery. All in all, the present monetary situation puts in the way of the vital goals of reducing unemployment and inflation. The foremost policy is to create low inflation and stable currencies.

Therefore ELDR demands:

- * the strict adherence to the convergence criteria as a precondition for the phase of the European Economic and Monetary Union;*
- * reinforced commitment to economic and monetary integration and a :*
- * strict adherence of all Member States to a stable monetary policy;*
- * the creation of independent national central banks as an immediate step towards establishing a European Central Bank;*
- * a tough and convergent fiscal policy, aimed at reducing budgetary deficits;*
- * a tax burden which allows the citizens to enjoy a substantial part of their savings.*

Whilst recognising that the current social and economic conditions make it difficult to fulfill the convergence criteria of the Maastricht Treaty according to its timetable, we support the long-term objective of EMU. We urge the European Monetary Institute to endeavour to promote consistency among EU central banks in their policy towards governments towards sound public finance, and for the EMI to collaborate closely with ECOFIN to establish coherent economic policies aimed at enhanced competitiveness and the reduction of unemployment.

The present situation in Europe, with floating exchange rates among several countries, is an objective of economic recovery. European citizens would all benefit from stable currencies and security in order to maximise job opportunities.

Therefore ELDR demands that:

- * the management of EMS should be adjusted to allow, if necessary, realignments, taking into account a fair "burden-sharing", aiming to avoid competitive devaluations and monetary turmoil and lay a sound foundation for the future.*

Social policy and employment

ELDR is working for the strengthening of the social dimension of the European Community to disenfranchise and marginalise millions of European citizens.

The liberal market economy has proven to be the best way to guarantee a high standard of living for the maximum of people, and to keep up the direction of social, technological and human progress.

The surest way to fight unemployment efficiently and permanently is to reduce unemployment and costs that kill all initiative, work and savings - thereby allowing individuals an opportunity to find and safeguard jobs.

Therefore ELDR demands that:

- * lower unemployment must be a major goal of Community social and*
- * workers and managers should be motivated by their own interest in big companies are concerned, by their joint participation in important d*

The Maastricht Treaty should be the starting point for addressing these problems. the development of social and labour market policies which promote a flexible and equality of opportunities and improvement of working conditions, especially among less qualified. The European labour market needs to become more flexible, but it will enhance European competitiveness by forcing workers to accept less safe, less healthy. All Member States should ensure a basic standard of living for all citizens, regardless

The completion of the Single Market will require businesses to rapidly adapt to its major consequences for employees. Retraining will become a continuing part of career. Use of the European Social Fund (ESF) for the co-financing of retraining programme is an element in building up the social dimension of the European Union.

Therefore ELDR demands:

- * the establishment of minimum standards of social provision through which to avoid the danger of exploiting the workforce;*
- * new approaches to the concept of work such as voluntary part-time career breaks for family and personal development, mobility of the workforce and those social costs affecting employers and employees which hinder the other labour market measures;*
- * that all remaining obstacles - legal barriers and discrimination - to equal opportunities between women and men be removed: this includes equal employment, taxation, and sharing family responsibilities; maternity provisions for both men and women to take care of their children; support for relatives who need special attention, as well as provision for affordable child care facilities;*
- * that a new approach to flexible retirement be found in the light of the challenges facing Europe;*
- * that the tax burden on labour be reduced and compensated for by an increase in environmentally damaging consumption and production;*
- * that in order to combat unemployment, we achieve competitive Europe;*
- * that non-public employment agencies be allowed to operate throughout the labour market performance;*
- * that the United Kingdom joins with the other eleven countries and a clause.*

Social and economic cohesion

Social and economic cohesion remains a priority for us. It is essential to clarify that the question of transfer of funds: in the terms of the Treaty, the principle of solidarity is a Community policy and action. Regional comparative advantage and competition investment decisions. Ecological sustainability must be incorporated into EU cohesion

Therefore ELDR demands that:

** cohesion policy should promote investment in environmental processes;*

** structural funds are used by regions to provide training and enhance the infrastructure of deprived and disadvantaged areas; investment limited to a certain period of time and be given to encourage self-help. the local, regional and European level must be improved;*

** as a significant contribution towards the Single Market, transnational telecommunications infrastructures should help weld national economies about economic recovery;*

** better public scrutiny and tighter financial control be introduced by the assistance of the Court of Auditors and under Parliamentary supervision. Auditors should be authorised to recommend sanctions;*

** special attention be given to a Community policy geared to the development of medium-sized enterprises necessary for their adaptation to new markets and new challenges on markets outside the Community.*

EU spending must be transparent and unbureaucratic and in line with the principles of good government.

The further development of industry and commerce in Europe requires a competitive entrepreneurial environment.

Europe needs a recovery strategy based on the convergence of macro-economic policies under Stage II of EMU. Common action is needed to increase investment in transport infrastructure, training, science, research and technology in ways that will strengthen and improve the environment and at the same time, provide for a phased reduction in public expenditure as the European economy recovers. The EU must identify which sectors of the economy are most likely to succeed. Within those sectors, industries and firms must be networked to devise coherent Research and Development strategies and to campaign for market access. The EU should focus its efforts on basic research too expensive to be undertaken by individual member states alone.

The Single Market must be made to work: vigorous competition within Europe will bring about greater competitiveness and provide a better deal for the consumer.

A SUSTAINABLE ENVIRONMENT

A sustainable environment is a global concern which can only be achieved through international co-operation and a common approach.

ELDR is convinced that not only can there be reconciliation between economic development and the environment, but also that the market economy in its response to present ecological challenges can create new jobs, new industries and thus economic growth. Events in Eastern Europe show that interventionist and centralised economies lead to ecological disaster, with alarm for public health.

Nature is a unique resource and its depletion and pollution must bear a price. An efficient economy in a healthy environment needs to manage its natural resources according to the principle of sustainability. This reconciliation of economy and ecology requires a change of consumption patterns. In general, market mechanisms are the most effective way in which to manage natural resources to create new economic opportunities, since they are least bureaucratic and allow maximum choice. Only where price mechanisms are ineffective should regulation be considered.

ELDR demands:

** internalising environmental costs in the economy: we need to shift*

labour to environmentally damaging consumption and production.

** the use of economic incentives and fiscal instruments to create an internal market, the Single Market, and so contribute to sustainability.*

These instruments must be particularly applied to the following three sectors:

- transport, which is a major source of economic development and a major source of pollution; taxation of fuel and road pricing for heavy trucks are appropriate means to limit further damage to the environment and enhance its economic management. The shift of transportation from road to rail should be encouraged.

- fossil fuels, which are a limited resource and whose use is a charge on the environment. Truly costed energy gives an incentive for conservation and makes renewable energy more competitive. A comprehensive system of energy efficiency standards for consumer products, industrial machinery and buildings must be introduced.

- agriculture, where the intensive use of certain substances is another source of pollution. Observance of the European rules in this field should not only be more strictly enforced but also be furthered by economic incentives and fiscal instruments. Recommendations by the Commission should further harmonise these instruments.

ELDR therefore supports:

** the immediate start to a phased implementation of a European-wide system of carbon trading; a major contribution to the fight against the greenhouse effect; and to ensure that energy, including nuclear power, bears the costs of their impact or that, when applying the tax, the principle of fiscal neutrality must be respected. The Commission should simultaneously work closely with the USA and Japan to achieve a similar tax in these countries.*

Sustainability also requires a real change in our approach to waste.

ELDR therefore supports:

** efforts to extend the life-cycle of products and the use of recycled raw materials.*

To reduce waste, our environmental priority ranking is: 1. avoidance, 2. re-use/recovery, 3. compost, 4. recycling, 5. compost, 6. landfill. Any downgrading should be justified by an impact assessment.

ELDR demands:

** international regulations to avoid uncontrolled dumping of hazardous waste.*

The incorporation of environmental factors in international trade is crucial to achieve a sustainable global level. As long as there is no international harmonisation of such legislation, there is a risk of trade distortion. Ecology is part of a dynamic development: it is to be seen as a stimulus for innovation, not a brake or a step backwards.

ELDR demands therefore that:

** tariffs or monetary compensatory amounts may be levied to avoid environmental dumping. These should be subject to negotiation within GATT.*

The risk of a nuclear disaster - caused either by old nuclear power stations or by new protected nuclear arms - represents a severe threat to all people of Europe.

ELDR therefore demands that:

** the EU provide the necessary funds to set up in an effective way training of nuclear engineers and specialists to advise the management of European nuclear power plants;*

** the EU promote conversion to cleaner industries and greater energy through energy saving programmes, in order to ensure the rapid practice and environmentally damaging use of energy in Central countries;*

** the Commission should undertake as a priority a comprehensive study of the safety and long-term viability and competitiveness of the nuclear energy in Europe.*

AGRICULTURE AND RURAL POLICY

European agricultural policy must create suitable underlying conditions so that economic and social challenges of today. With its agricultural policy ELDR entrepreneurial and competitive market-oriented agriculture in harmony with the environment would thus be best able to achieve the high quality required by today's consumers environment and also to maintain the diversity of cultivated landscapes.

The CAP was conceived to ensure stable markets, security of food supply, a fair and reasonable prices for the consumer. But it has become a good example of EU overregulation.

Administrative control of the reformed CAP becomes more difficult every year. For the CAP was to guarantee prices by market regulation. Farmers who sought increased production. New techniques of mechanisation, enhanced use of chemicals and animal breeding led to ever greater increases in production and intensification. The market was over-supplied.

ELDR wants a new CAP which actively embodies the principle of sustainability and is convinced that market mechanisms should be strengthened in order to bring production in line with market needs. We recognise that the eventual loss of income resulting from meeting national and regional targets must be compensated for, and underline that this approach must be taken into account during the GATT negotiations. Payment will depend on a number of fundamental factors: the risk of desertification and depopulation of some rural regions where agriculture is the main activity; protection of the countryside and landscape; and in peripheral countries, the unique character of the economy on agriculture.

The consumers' interest in reasonable prices and good food quality are as important as the interests of producers. In any case consumers and tax payers must know the real price of the food.

The process of reform in farming must continue, particularly as the EU allows wider exports from our new partners in Central and Eastern Europe.

Rural economies need help to diversify if they are to survive as thriving and dynamic. The CAP needs to be transformed into a common rural policy with the clear aim of supporting rural communities and the countryside. Policy should be directed at providing farmers with the means to survive rather than at paying high prices for surplus food production.

Therefore, ELDR demands that:

** the market place plays a much bigger role through the progressive introduction of management mechanisms to income support schemes, aiming to increase the profitability of agricultural activity in the Union;*

** EMU be created as set out in the Maastricht Treaty in order to rule out excessive price fluctuations in agricultural markets;*

- * the European Union affirms the desirability of ensuring food sufficiency and well-functioning agriculture;*
- * the future agricultural policy of the Community should rely to the greatest extent on market forces to determine the output of agricultural products;*
- * a code of good conduct be adopted to define agricultural practice respecting soil, water, air and biological diversity;*
- * payment of subsidies will depend on following this code;*
- * CAP rules must be scrupulously enforced throughout the Community;*
- * agricultural activities which put a burden on the environment should have their costs be assessed and charged to the enterprise according to the polluter principle;*
- * while food production is a matter for market mechanism and EU payments for the protection of landscape, biotopes and rural areas should be organised and financed on a regional basis, that is according to the principle that it is important that policy allows for economic support which makes it possible for people in rural areas to continue working in new activities not requiring excessive subsidies from taxpayers and consumers;*
- * structural changes in farming which reduce employment prospects should be matched by measures in the strategic framework of rural development which enable people to remain in rural areas, thus avoiding depopulation;*
- * the current system of set-aside by rotation be phased out, and per hectare benefit to the environment be found for land that is no longer viable for agriculture;*
- * extensive agricultural practice be encouraged and stimulation be given to:*
 - scientific research into non-food use of farm production*
 - new industries using farm products.*

We want to see an attractive and productive rural environment with a range of family-run, occupying the central role in thriving rural communities that provide a variety of activities. Structural funds should encourage the cooperation needed to reach this goal.

CIVIL RIGHTS AND JUSTICE

Building a citizens' Europe

Liberals, Democrats and Reformers have always been in the forefront of the struggle for civil rights and justice. We therefore adhere to the principle that any policy should be based on the respect for the rights of individuals, without any kind of discrimination. Any person having the nationality of a Member State of the Union and should enjoy the same civil and political rights and liberties as any other citizen of the Union. In due course, these common rights, together with measures to protect the rights of all non-EU citizens, should be prescribed in a European Constitution including Citizenship attached to the Treaties. As a first step, the European Convention on Human Rights and Fundamental Freedoms and its relevant Protocols should be ratified by the EU, the Convention should be made justiciable in the European Court of Justice and the Court of First Instance.

Border control and judicial cooperation

The European Union will have no internal boundaries and those remaining now are in order to prevent the abuse of free movement of people, goods, services and Union, we need certain measures to be taken to curb terrorism and other forms develop a common policy at the external borders of the Union. Up to now, nations have been much too secretive about these quite normal activities taking place within EU, within the intergovernmental Treaty agreements and under the Schengen Treaty such intergovernmental agreements should be signed by all Member States and incorporated into Treaties so that they become justiciable by the Court of Justice and subject to democratic control.

In particular, ELDR insists that:

- * the police and judiciary are entitled to operate throughout the Union in a coordinated way; agreement should be reached on indictment control and the fight against money laundering;*
- * the authorities shall not be allowed to take any action without parliamentary scrutiny;*
- * all Member States must ensure fulfilment of their Treaty obligations, particularly the freedom of movement of people;*
- * Europol must be established as an effective instrument to fight against drug trafficking, and to allow for the confiscation of goods gained from*

Immigration and Asylum

We are aware of the fact that a European immigration and refugee policy cannot be based on the problem of immigration. This is only possible through the improvement of living conditions and the control of origin of those who migrate to and within Europe.

People have the right to move around. We live in and benefit from an open society where people live in harmony and freely express their personality - whatever their ethnic, religious or political beliefs. Nevertheless, the increasing number of refugees in Europe and the abolition of borders between Member States make it urgently necessary to introduce common European Union policies on asylum seekers and refugees. ELDR is led by the principle that politically persecuted people should be granted political asylum in all Member States of the Union. We should share the responsibility for the admission, settlement and support for asylum seekers and refugees. Close collaboration with Central and Eastern Europe and the Mediterranean countries, is essential if the Union is to solve the social, economic and political dimension of the problem.

To this end, ELDR demands that:

- * anybody is initially allowed to enter an EU Member State if they are not persecuted which is not manifestly ill-founded, and if they do not enter the State;*
- * the fight against illegal immigration leading to third country citizens within the EU, be intensified by increased cooperation between Member States;*
- * common criteria and legislation for asylum with separate legislation for political refugees created; the distinction between the two must accord with the conventions;*
- * the fight against illegal immigration be intensified by increased cooperation between Member States and that common standards in matters relating to issuing visas, control at the entry to European Union territory be elaborated;*

** once the application for entry has been rejected by one Member State bound by this refusal;*

** the right of appeal against refusal shall exist, according to national interpretation facilities provided;*

** applicants shall be assisted during these proceedings, which should be*

** the burden of costs and services of asylum and refugee treatment shall be shared equitably between member states.*

CULTURE, YOUTH AND EDUCATION

ELDR wants a Europe rich in cultural diversity - tolerant of and knowledgeable about European citizenship should be fostered through youth and cultural exchange programmes. We develop a European dimension in education.

We strongly support the rights of cultural minorities, and believe that such groups should have their own language, schools and media.

Contrary to widespread fears, we believe that cultural diversity and tolerance is essential for integration because it encourages and increases exchange of experience between the most important factor of European integration.

Youth and education

Young people represent the future and continuity of every society. With their lives open minds, youth are the key to European integration and our investment in them to enhance their knowledge of each other, the EU should encourage mobility within this

ELDR therefore urges:

** the encouragement of the teaching of at least two foreign languages in the school curricula of all EU member states at the earliest possible age;*

** that Member States encourage civic education by the teaching of the history of the EU at all levels;*

** a substantial increase in exchange programmes for all young people and people in education, in the EU: these programmes should preferably be on an individual basis, person-to-person and family-to-family;*

** that the EU should encourage Member States to introduce a period of compulsory education system;*

** that the EU must guarantee the mutual recognition of exams throughout the Community;*

** the EU-wide availability and distribution of European films and television;*

** that a European media initiative be developed to bring the European idea to the citizens of the Union.*

ACTING TOGETHER IN INTERNATIONAL POLITICS

Security Policy and External Relations

After the end of East-West confrontation, European foreign policy should provide a system of security and cooperation on our continent, in close cooperation with Canada. Strong partnerships with the United Nations (UN) as well as the Conference for Security and Cooperation in Europe (CSCE), North Atlantic Treaty Organisation (NATO) including the North Atlantic Cooperation Council (NACC) and the European Union are

There is a need for a new concept of security in a multi-polar world, comprising traditional military dimension, economic, sociological and ecological dimensions. They want the European Union to play a major role in the pursuit of human rights, social development on the one hand, and to fight against racism and deprivation on the other. The common foreign and security policy consistent with the substance of our domestic policy with the Union's proper legal and political processes. Its aims should be the creation of a stable and secure environment and an intensification of relationships with the developed countries, commitment to human and civil rights worldwide and the fight against racism and discrimination with enormous responsibilities. The European Union must play a major part in reforming the end of the Cold War to secure peace and to enhance the global protection of the environment.

In a time of fundamental change in Europe, NATO remains the most important organisation for defence and stability. ELDR supports the European-American partnership within the Atlantic Alliance. However, Europe must assume more responsibility within the transatlantic partnership. The European Union, an integral part of the European Union, represents the European pillar within this partnership.

Within Europe, it is up to the Union to play a major security role. We should move towards a situation where the Union will have a limited but effective military force for rapid reaction to conflicts within Europe.

The next revision of the Treaty should prepare the way for the foreign and security policy of the Maastricht Treaty to be rolled up into the Union, and for the Union to assume the role of the West European Union (WEU). Neutrality amongst certain existing or new Member States should not obstruct the development of armed European Union forces, operational in defence, peace-keeping.

ELDR demands:

- * the establishment of a European security and defence policy and the structures and forces to implement it;*
- * the strict adherence to the timetables for and implementation of the agreements, restraint of arms exports and an end to production and possession of weapons of mass destruction;*
- * that the European Union plays a major part in reforming the UN to enable it to secure peace more quickly and efficiently, to improve the protection of the environment;*

Enlargement

ELDR welcomes the prospect of the accession of Austria, Finland, Norway and Sweden to the European Union. The unreserved commitment of these countries to the "acquis communautaire" and the Maastricht Treaty should enable a rapid conclusion of the accession negotiations. The countries, with their deep democratic tradition, will further strengthen democratic values and making processes within the Union.

ELDR therefore demands that:

** the European Union remains open to new members who have f "acquis communautaire" and the "acquis politique";*

** with the enlargement of the European Union, a reform of the struct be carried out which maintains the capability of its institutions to representation of all Member States and strengthens the rights of th through specific reforms concerning the elimination of the demo consolidation of the principles and aims on which Political Union is base*

Central and Eastern Europe

Most Central and East European countries with which the European Union has agreements have established democratic and peaceful societies. In order to foster indispensable to open up European Union markets to their products. ELDR looks accession of these countries.

ELDR believes that the Union must give all possible support to the economic and environmental improvement and social stability of Russia and the other former R Union.

ELDR therefore demands:

** the forging of close and open partnerships with all genuine demo Eastern Europe, and that the European Union further opens its markets*

** that the EU seek a friendly partnership with Russia on a broad b; cooperation of all new independent states within the region, especial the Ukraine, which is essential for stability and peace within the r reflected in special cooperation agreements with the European Union, the 8th member of the Economic Summit;*

** that all democratic countries work towards the creation of an all-Euro*

** that all countries work towards the development of direct investm technologies to Central and East European countries.*

Development Policy

North-South cooperation must be conceived within a global context, be based on th rights, the environment and free and fair trade. To this end, ELDR considers that t from a phase of mere "coordination" of the twelve development policies, to a lead European development policy; ELDR greets therefore with satisfaction the incorpo cooperation into the Maastricht Treaty, allowing the EU to complement and coord policies in this area. It is natural for those living in persecution, conflict and pover and prosperity. Successful development policy and the establishment of just, f societies in the countries concerned is the only way to remove the main cause for m

ELDR therefore demands that:

** a rapid and balanced conclusion of the GATT Uruguay Round be acq prerequisite of the success of economic reform; international protection.*

** the resources for future generations be preserved. Environment, included in the cooperation with developing countries. Furthermore eff allow development funds to be used for financing the possibly higher (*

to environmental requirements;

** the developing countries put in place sustainable democratic and economic systems, allow individuals to participate fully in political processes and use their resources to their advantage;*

** development aid should be concentrated on those countries which are developing democracy, are setting up a market economy, pursue environmental policies, efficiently control population growth and restrict military spending;*

** Member States continue to aim for the international target of 0.7% of GDP for development aid, and for a greater effectiveness in its use;*

** industrialised countries must contribute to easing the debt burden of developing countries by further opening their markets and by debt rescheduling: any proposal should be evaluated on individual merit;*

** development policy must help people to help themselves: its effectiveness should be increased;*

** the EU regards as a priority the development of its relations with the Mediterranean Basin, particularly those of North Africa, and builds up links directly to the social, economic and political stability of that region.*

THE FUTURE OF DEMOCRACY IN THE UNION

The European Union is unique. No blueprint exists. ELDR has for many years sought to transform the European Community into a European Union with decentralised federal characteristics.

This is not the centralised all-powerful European superstate caricatured by our national and international media. Under an institutional framework, democratic authorities at different levels - national and supranational - share power with each other in a coordinated way. Our institutions that govern the EU efficiently, using light regulation wherever possible, and preserve the decentralised federal character.

We demand a European constitution to be drafted by the European Parliament in consultation with the other EU political institutions, the national parliaments and governments.

The provisions of the European constitution must reflect as closely as possible the principles of democratic control of the Union, lack of transparency in the EU and the loss of national, regional and cultural identity.

ELDR demands that:

** the European Union be democratic at all levels, fair to its citizens, open to all activities, and embody the principles of human rights, including respect for minorities;*

** co-decision between Parliament and Council, which is the key to the functioning of the European Union, must be made to apply to all legislation;*

** modifications of the Treaties on which the process of European integration is based be subject to the assent of the European Parliament;*

** at the political level, a separation of powers should be accomplished which should consist of a directly elected parliament, which embodies the peoples of Europe, and the Council, which represents the political majorities of the Member States. Both branches of the legislative power must operate on the basis of the principle of transparency and should meet and decide in public;*

** the Council of Ministers must evolve into a full democratic legislative body; the voting record of the Council should be public; another step towards majority-vote decision making within the Council to other main policies;*

** a uniform electoral procedure be introduced for the European Parliament, broadly matching votes cast: fair votes for the citizen and equal treatment;*

** the appointment of the Commission as the executive body of the EU by the legislature (European Parliament and Council) within sixty days;*

Intergovernmental arrangements among Member States should be incorporated in the framework.

ELDR considers that the political recognition of the regional dimension embodied in the Union through the Committee of Regions, represents an encouraging advance from both the involvement of local and regional authorities in the construction of Europe and improving the effectiveness of the structural policies of the Union.

ELDR therefore demands that:

** the two intergovernmental pillars of the Treaty of Maastricht arrangements such as the Schengen Agreement be brought fully under the European Union, and eventually involve all Member States;*

** European integration at variable speed - although it may be unavoidable - does not lead to a Europe "à la carte";*

** the Committee of the Regions develops rapidly into a powerful regional and local institutions.*

The ELDR requests that by 1996 the European Union be based on a Constitution with the citizen vis-à-vis the Union, its competence and the rule of democratic law. The Constitution must also include a Charter of Rights for the European citizen.

The constitutional settlement shall only be brought into effect by popular endorsement and practices of individual Member States.

Manifesto of the Liberal Democrat and Reform Group

16 June 1993, 40th anniversary of the LDR Group

The Members of the Liberal, Democrat and Reform Group have been firm supporters from the very beginning. Their objective has been not simply to turn Europe into a belief was that a shared political future should bring together the democratic nations in a guarantee of peace and to enable them to act together resolutely in a world of superpowers and threatened by totalitarian ideology.

Today, forty years after a Liberal, Democratic and Reform Group was created in the face of the threats have changed because the world has changed. But these changes serve to reaffirm our commitment towards a European Union which respects the national identity of its members. The creation of this Union calls for an act of political will as it cannot come about as a consequence of economic integration. Our Europe is not just a Europe of business and individuals. The Maastricht Treaty which the Liberals support, as they have supported for Political Union, has confirmed this approach.

The Liberals are working towards completion of Political and Economic and Monetary Union with the timetable set out in the Maastricht Treaty. They want the ECU to become a single currency. They support the development of new Community policies, particularly in the technology sector. Decentralised federalism which they advocate implies the powers which cannot best be exercised at the local, regional or national level should be exercised at the European level. Their concern for good management means they apply this principle of balanced budgets avoiding any form of inefficiency.

Their attachment to parliamentary democracy underlies their vision of European Union. They are opposed to excessive bureaucracy and any slide towards a purely technocratic system. They seek a new balance between the institutions by strengthening the democratic powers of the European Parliament which should be elected by a uniform system of proportional representation. They want extensive political, legislative and budgetary powers. Their vision of Europe is first and foremost a Europe of citizens.

It is also a Europe of openness. Freedom of movement of persons, which needs to be guaranteed, will herald European citizenship defined by the rights and duties common to all Europeans. It requires development of a system of education better able to bring out each individual's talents and to combine the finest traditions of humanism and which will increase opportunities for each individual while removing constraints on freedom of thought.

It is also a balanced Europe. A balance between countries and regions, between urban and rural areas. The Common Agricultural Policy needs to create an equilibrium which will guarantee reasonable prices for consumers while holding out the prospect of growth and employment for family farms. The Members of the LDR Group want Europe to provide policies enabling a balance, not a divorce, to be achieved between industrial development and protection of the environment.

Finally, it is a Europe of solidarity. Solidarity within the Union through greater cohesion: completion of the Single Internal Market should be accompanied by voluntary measures in favour of the least favoured regions and sections of society. Solidarity with the rest of the world: the LDR Group believes that Europe is One. They want the Union to be open to the other European countries. They want Europe emerging from its years of captivity, with which there is a need for close political and economic aid pending accession at some point in the future, when the countries in question will be up in material terms and the process of building Europe has been strengthened. Solidarity with the rest of the world: cooperation with developing countries, often particularly in the field of agriculture, needs to be improved. The priority areas are self-sufficiency in food and the promotion of small projects by small businesses. Aid should not be frittered away on administrative expenses but should be directed towards projects. Furthermore aid should be accompanied by initiatives on human rights.

With regard to Europe's external policy, which presupposes a defence policy in line with the very concept of Union, the Liberals expect something more than the creation of a common foreign policy. Their ultimate objective is to make Europe a paragon and an example in terms of civilisation, emancipation and development of the individual and dialogue between cultures. A Europe of enlightenment.